

The Charcuterie Cheat Sheet

How much to buy for any party, on one page.

PER GUEST

	BEFORE A MEAL	THE PARTY FOOD	THE MEAL
Cured meat	2 oz	3 oz	4 oz
Cheese	2 oz	3 oz	4 oz
Crackers and bread	6–8 pieces	10–12 pieces	12–15 pieces
Fruit	2 oz	3 oz	4 oz
Nuts	0.5 oz	1 oz	1 oz
Olives and pickles	1 oz	1.5 oz	2 oz

From 20 guests, add 10%. Round cheese up to the half pound, the way it's sold.

TOTALS BEFORE A MEAL (APPETIZER)

GUESTS	4	8	12	20	30	50
Cured meat	8 oz	1 lb	1½ lb	2¾ lb	4¼ lb	7 lb
Cheese	8 oz	1 lb	1½ lb	3 lb	4½ lb	7 lb
Crackers	24–32	48–64	72–96	120–160	180–240	300–400
Cheeses / meats	3 / 2	3 / 2	3–4 / 3	4–5 / 3–4	4–5 / 3–4	5–6 / 4–5

BOARD SIZE

4 guests	One 12–14 inch board
8 guests	One 16–18 inch board
12 guests	One large 22–28 inch board
20 guests	Two boards, or two stations on one table
30 guests	Two boards, or two stations on one table
50 guests	A grazing table, or three stations

Any other guest count?

The free Party Planner works it out for 4 to 100 guests, with cost and a prep timeline:
charcuterielab.com/party-planner

Build it, time it, pair it

The rules that make a board taste better, not just look better.

BUILD ORDER

- 1 Bowls first** Place jars and small bowls for honey, jam, mustard and olives. They anchor the layout.
- 2 Cheeses** Spread them out, far apart, so every side of the board has one.
- 3 Cured meats** Fold, ribbon or river them next to the cheeses they pair with.
- 4 Fruit and produce** Fill the medium gaps with grapes, figs, apple or pear slices.
- 5 Nuts and small things** Fill every small gap so no board shows through.
- 6 Crackers** Add them within 30 minutes of serving so they stay crisp.
- 7 Garnish and check** Herb sprigs last, then check that nothing is still fridge-cold.

TAKE IT OUT OF THE FRIDGE

Aged hard cheese	45–60 min
Semi-firm cheese	30–45 min
Soft cheese (brie, camembert)	20–30 min
Fresh cheese (mozzarella, chèvre)	15–20 min
Cured meats	15–20 min

PAIR BY CONTRAST

- Salty + sweet** aged cheddar or Parmigiano with honey, fig jam or dried apricot
- Rich + acidic** brie or salami with cornichons, green apple or mustard
- Creamy + crunchy** soft cheese with nuts, crisp crackers or toasted baguette
- Mild + bold** one gentle cheese, one sharp, one blue, so every bite differs

FOOD SAFETY

Perishable food should sit out no more than 2 hours, or 1 hour above 90°F (USDA). For a long party, put out half and refill from the fridge instead of leaving it all out.

Want the whole board planned for you?

50 Boards Built by Science has 50 complete boards, each with a shopping list, amounts and prices, and a timed build. charcuterielab.com/ebook